

Michelangelo

Sculptor, painter, architect and poet, Michelangelo di Lodovico Buonarroti (1475–1564) was apprenticed to Ghirlandaio, then trained as a sculptor under the patronage of Lorenzo de' Medici. He first worked in Florence, Bologna and then Rome, where he carved the lifelike, emotive *Pietà* – the grieving Virgin Mary holding her dead son – from a single piece of marble.

From 1501 in Florence, among other projects, he produced the 4.3-metre (14.2-ft) statue of the biblical King David that became a symbol of the city. In 1505, he returned once more to Rome to create a tomb for Pope Julius II, a project that stopped and started until 1545. From 1508 to 1512, he painted over 300 life-sized figures in complex, dynamic poses and exuberant colour on the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel, portraying scenes of the Old Testament. Among many other commissions, in 1546, he was made chief architect of St Peter's Basilica. Nicknamed 'Il Divino' ('the Divine One') for his artistic genius, he was the first Western artist to have a biography published during his lifetime.



Michelangelo, *Pietà*, 1498–9